



1. *Paromita Banerjee, 53, owner of a handloom outlet, in Kolkata*
2. *A weaver in Maharashtra working on an intricate design*

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intricate workmanship, is, after all, a simple collection of wooden strips and string. Scores of young weavers returned to previously unappreciated family occupations, and are cashing in on their new value today.

The Covid years brought economic hardship all over the world. Several international brands went out of business. With this came introspection, and consequently the consciousness about the wastefulness of mass production systems and perpetually changing fashion trends. 'Slow fashion', 'green' and 'low' carbon footprint' became desirable brand attributes. And handloom processes ticked all the boxes. Thus, the very reasons due to which handloom had become unpopular brought it into the mainstream again.

There has been a post-Covid rediscovery of handloom. This includes even traditional styles such as sarees and kurtas. It is great too to see that the young Indian male, after decades of dull, dark terylene suits and bush-shirts, is embracing vibrant Indian prints again. Ikat, Shibori, block print, linen and Tussar are in demand, and Jamawar shawls and stunning Banarsi brocades are worn by both men and women. As the demand grows, so does the number of young designers and entrepreneurs who are infusing innovation and fresh ideas into old traditions.

Amid this success, however, one of the problems handloom weavers continue to face is a shortage of the right locally available raw material due to industrialisation in traditional cotton, silk and wool cultivation sectors and their high prices on account of being exported abroad. This has been partially alleviated by the development of locally grown new materials like banana, bamboo, water chestnut, nettle, etc. Though still in early stages, they have huge potential and can also generate local employment opportunities.

Last but not least, may I put in a word for humble NGOs, like my own Dastkar, which over the decades have offered weavers and other artisans constructive marketing platforms in metro cities. Some of India's most successful weaver groups, whether from Banaras, Bhagalpur or Bhujodi, first entered the urban market through Dastkar. Now, they proudly supply to the Tarun Tahilianis and Rohit Bals of the fashion world, but also keep their feet firmly on the ground, retailing directly.

Long sidelined but so full of potential, what the handloom sector needs now is investment. Only 15 per cent of Indian cloth is handloom-produced, but 95 per cent of the world's handloom is made in India. A French traveller in the 17th century had said that Indian handlooms circled the globe. How lovely it would be for this beautiful sector to do so again. ■

WHAT HELPED WEAVERS

- Internet and social media have given them direct access to markets
- The 2020 migrant exodus made artisans aware of the value of having skills they could practise at home
- Development of new materials such as banana, bamboo, water chestnut, nettle, bark, etc.
- Post-Covid rediscovery of handicraft and handloom
- Handloom sale is no longer confined to state and Khadi emporia
- Growing focus on slow, sustainable fashion
- The emergence of NGOs has provided marketing platforms to craftspeople, enabling them to sell directly to urban consumers
- Designers and entrepreneurs are responding to the growing demand, and government schemes to promote the sector are helping